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What if, even if: A transformation through the power of prayer

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Abstract

Humans constantly face unpredictable events outside their control, resulting in a “What If” stream of consciousness. “What if I lose my job?” “What if I do not pass my board exams?” “What if I become sick and disabled?” “What if my loved one dies?” This negative mindset is full of fear and worrisome imaginations, bringing constant misery to the individual. In order to be saved from the tortures of the “What Ifs,” both modern and ancient research suggest that it can be helpful to develop faith. This article analyzes the ancient Hindu scriptures to understand the importance of faith and the power of the transformative force that catalyzes the shift from the “What ifs” to the “Even ifs.” “Even if I have to face the reality of my worst fears, I will have faith and surrender to the Divine.” This paper also explores the mental and physical health benefits of regular prayer as an incentive to encourage more prayer, ultimately leading one toward heightened spirituality.

Keyword: Faith, Hindu scriptures, what if mindset, even if transformation, prayer benefits, spiritual well-being

Introduction

In Sanskrit, Faith is known as śraddhā, and it is the central aspect of Hindu spiritual practice. Śraddhā highlights unwavering trust in the divine and is the key to salvation (mokṣa), a soul's union with the Divine with liberation from the cycle of birth and death (Warrier, 2006)^[16]. In the *Bhagavad Gītā* (Chapter 6, verse 47), Lord Krishna explains the great value of absolute faith:

yoginām api sarveṣāṃ madgatenāntarātmanā
śraddhāvān bhajate yo mām sa me yuktatamo mataḥ

Translation: "Among all yogis, the one who worships Me with faith, with their heart and soul focused on Me, is the most united with Me and highest of all."

To achieve this absolute faith, one must develop an initial trust in the Hindu scriptures like the *Bhagavad Gītā*, *Vedas*, and *Upaniṣads*. Through spiritual teachings, one becomes inspired to seek knowledge and follow rituals. Once this initial faith is established, the ancient scriptures guide one to engage in prayer. By praying, a person can start experiencing the presence, power, and grace of the Divine, resulting in spiritual growth and inner peace. These experiences confirm their initial beliefs, making their faith even stronger. As faith grows, devotion becomes deeper, creating a unique interconnectedness between faith and devotion (Thompson, 2017)^[15]. Through the power of prayer, a person surrenders their personal will and aligns themselves with the will of the Divine. They start to understand that the Divine knows what is best for them and that the outcome of prayers will be for their highest good. This act of surrender fuels the "What if" transition to "Even if."

What is Prayer?

Prayer is a spiritual practice in which individuals communicate with the divine or seek a connection with a higher power. There are two types of prayer in Hinduism (Temple Purohit, 2017)^[13]:

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1. **Personal and Devotional Prayer (Bhakti):** This type of prayer is a personal form of communication with the Divine. It may involve chanting mantras, singing hymns (bhajans), meditating, or reciting sacred texts like the Bhagavad Gītā or the Vedas. The devotee believes that a higher power will listen and respond to their heartfelt devotion.
2. **Ritualistic Prayer (Puja):** These prayers are performed with the faith that following specific rituals will bring blessings or remove obstacles by pleasing the Divine.

Mental and Physical Health Benefits of Prayer

Before one can truly have faith in the scriptures and experience the high-level spiritual rewards of prayer, it may be beneficial to understand its mental and physical health benefits first.

In recent years, a growing body of research suggests a strong correlation between prayer and mental health. Below is a review of some key findings:

A large-scale study of 10,000+ participants published in the *American Journal of Epidemiology* in 2018 found that young adults who prayed daily tended to have greater psychological well-being, with higher levels of life satisfaction, character strengths, and positive affect. They had fewer depressive symptoms and a lower risk of mental illness compared to those who never prayed (Chen & VanderWeele, 2018)^[2].

A 2010 study published in the *International Journal of Psychiatry in Medicine* found that participants receiving prayer intervention (1 hour/6x week) showed significant improvement in depression and anxiety with increases in optimism and daily spiritual experiences compared to controls. The subjects in the prayer group maintained these significant improvements for at least one month after the final prayer session (Boelens, Reeves, Replogle, & Koenig, 2010)^[1].

A 2018 study conducted at Walden University examined the benefits of prayer on depression in elderly adults over time. Subjects who prayed over a three-year period showed a significant decrease in depression compared to those people who did not pray (Leet, 2018)^[6].

Along with the mental benefits, considerable research has examined the health benefits of praying. According to Dr. Herbert Benson, a Harvard Medical School Cardiovascular Specialist, prayer and meditation have potential healing benefits by stimulating a relaxation response, which lowers blood pressure and breathing rate. It counteracts the negative impact of stress, which is tied to decreased cardiovascular health (Dossey, 1993)^[4]. A study conducted at Duke University Medical Center with 1700 subjects found that those who attended religious services and prayed had healthier immune systems than those who did not. The researchers speculate that religious activity can positively affect immunity by promoting positive thoughts and behavior (Cohen & Koenig, 1997)^[3].

A 2015 meta-analysis of 1500 reputable medical studies by Duke University's Center for Spirituality, Theology, and Health reported that people who were more religious and prayed more had better mental and physical health outcomes (Nelson, 2025)^[8].

Neurotheology

An emerging field of study called "Neurotheology" seeks to understand the relationship between the human brain and spirituality. This interdisciplinary "Spiritual Neuroscience" explores how spiritual practices, such as prayer and meditation, affect cognitive and neural functioning on a

scientific level. Studies in this area provide scientific evidence that prayer can change the human brain, resulting in positive mental and physical health outcomes.

Andrew Newburg is a pioneer in this field, and he uses brain imaging techniques (e.g., MRI, SPECT) in his research. He found that prayer and meditation stimulate the prefrontal cortex, which controls self-awareness, moral decision-making, empathy, and emotional regulation (Newburg, 2021). Further research by Dr. Caroline Leaf, a cognitive neuroscientist, showed that 12 minutes of focused prayer a day reshapes the brain through the concept of neuroplasticity. Consistent prayer affects the brain's wiring (e.g., synaptic connections) and chemistry (e.g., hormones), particularly the frontal lobes, which are responsible for personality, attention, making decisions, and empathizing with others. Activating and strengthening the frontal lobes promotes mental and emotional balance on a physiological level (The Bridge Fellowship, 2024)^[14].

Research has shown that individuals who pray regularly have thicker frontal lobes and exhibit lower levels of stress hormones, like cortisol, resulting in greater feelings of peace and well-being. When stressed, the limbic system becomes hyper-activated, either thrusting one into a flight-or-flight survival mode or freezing. This response results in a shutdown of executive functioning and prevents clear thinking. In this state of mind, they can make poor and self-destructive decisions. When a person prays, the prefrontal cortex (the most anterior part of the frontal lobe) becomes re-activated, allowing for improved decision-making and emotional regulation (Specter, 2017)^[12]. Other studies in this area show that prayer facilitates the release of "feel-good" hormones such as serotonin, dopamine, and oxytocin, which contribute to feelings of hope and happiness (Scull, 2025)^[11]. This paper provides a brief overview of the neurological connection of the human brain to prayer. Praying fosters a spiritual connection with the Divine and is a physical workout for the brain, resulting in mental and physical benefits.

Spiritual Benefits of Prayer

The ancient Hindu scriptures contain extensive discussions on prayer and its significance in spiritual practice. Below is a brief overview of some key ancient texts highlighting the power of prayer, devotion, and the impact of sincere worship.

The Bhagavad Gītā (Chapter 9, Verse 22)

ananyāś cintayanto mām ye janāḥ paryupāsate,
teṣāṁ nityābhiyuktānām yoga-kṣhemam vahāmyaḥam

Translation: "To those who are constantly devoted and always remember me with undivided hearts, I carry what they lack and preserve what they have."

This verse highlights Lord Krishna's promise to protect and support those devotees who pray with pure and continuous devotion.

Viṣṇu Sahasranāma (Phalaśruti Verse)

yaḥ idaṁ śṛṇuyāt nityaṁ yaś cāpi parikīrtayet,
nāśubhaṁ prāpnuyāt kiñcid so'mutreha ca mānavāḥ.

Translation: Whoever hears or recites these names of Lord Vishnu daily will never meet with inauspiciousness either in this world or in the next.

This ancient text confirms that those who pray by reciting Viṣṇu's name daily will be rewarded in this life and the next.

Daily prayer protects and purifies one's life. This verse shows that faithful prayers result in Viṣṇu's grace and rewards of knowledge, wisdom, and purity, which are all necessary to attain salvation.

Skaṇḍa Purāṇa

nāsti teṣāṃ yaśaḥ kāle na punarbhava-bhañjanam,
ye stuvanti harer nāma satataṃ prārthanānvitāḥ.

Translation: Those who constantly praise the name of Lord Hari with prayerful hearts never lose their glory and are freed from the cycle of rebirth.

This scripture demonstrates the power of prayer to achieve liberation.

Examining various verses from the ancient scriptures reveals that true, heartfelt prayer brings many spiritual rewards to the devotee. Whether through chanting mantras, singing hymns, or engaging in meditative practices, the scriptures consistently convey that prayer is a means to connect with the Divine and achieve spiritual growth, peace, and liberation (Temple Purohit, 2017)^[13].

Conclusion

In conclusion, faith forms the foundation of a meaningful and resilient life, and prayer is the bridge that nurtures and strengthens that faith. Through consistent prayer, individuals experience a deepened spiritual connection and profound mental and physical health benefits, reducing stress, cultivating emotional stability, and promoting physical well-being. As faith matures through prayer, it evolves from a fragile "what if" mindset filled with doubts and uncertainties to a steadfast "even if" mindset rooted in unwavering trust and surrender to the Divine. This inner transformation prepares the soul for its ultimate journey: breaking free from the endless cycle of birth and death and attaining salvation. In this way, prayer becomes a vital practice that leads to spiritual liberation, offering wholeness for the body, mind, and soul in this life and beyond.

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